A SERMON FOR THE PULPIT

The Man Who Never Asked

A sermon on the man born blind

THE BIG IDEA

The light comes to the man who never asked, and goes looking for him after the room casts him out.

PRIMARY TEXT	John 9:1–41
ALSO READ	John 10:1–18; Genesis 2:7; 2 Kings 20:20; Isaiah 8:6; Nehemiah 3:15
TIME	50–60 minutes, including a 3–5 minute response.

Scripture quotations are ESV. Swap to your pulpit translation freely.

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Introduction: The question in the street

If you had been standing there, you would have heard the question before you saw the man.

Jesus and his disciples were walking through Jerusalem. John does not tell us which street. He does not tell us the hour. He tells us what they saw: a man blind from birth. And he tells us what the disciples said.

"Rabbi, who sinned, this man or his parents, that he was born blind?"

That is the question. It sounds spiritual. It sounds compassionate, even. It is the question people ask when they see suffering and want the world to make sense. Somebody must be responsible. Somebody must have done something. Find the cause, close the file.

But look at where the question is aimed. The man is sitting right there. He can hear every word. They are discussing the reason for his suffering with him three feet away. They do not ask his name. They do not ask how he is. They do not ask what he needs. They ask whose fault he is.

He is not a person in that sentence. He is a condition. A case study. A theological problem with a heartbeat.

And that is the first thing I want you to see in this story. Before the mud, before the pool, before the interrogation, before the worship in the street, there is a room full of people talking about a man who is standing in the middle of their sentence.

We do this. We do it in hospitals. We do it in families. We do it in church lobbies. We see a body that does not work the way we think a body should work, or a life that has not gone the way we think a life should go, and we reach for a cause. We want the equation. We want the verdict. We want to be able to say, "That is why."

The disciples wanted the equation. Jesus refused it.

"Jesus answered, 'It was not that this man sinned, or his parents, but that the works of God might be displayed in him'" (John 9:3).

Not a curse. Not a verdict with an address. A stage.

Then he said something with urgency running underneath it: "We must work the works of him who sent me while it is day; night is coming, when no one can work. As long as I am in the world, I am the light of the world" (John 9:4–5).

The light of the world was standing within arm's reach of a man who had never seen light.

And here is the detail that should stop you: the man never asks to be healed. Read the chapter again. He does not cry out. He does not reach for Jesus. He does not bargain. He does not even know who Jesus is. In the entire story, the man who receives his sight never once asks for it.

The light walked over to the darkness and crouched down beside it.

That is the story we are going to walk through this morning. It is a story about a man nobody asked, a healer nobody expected, and a room that would rather keep its file than receive its sight. It is a story about a man who was thrown out and then found. And it is a story about the light that comes looking before we know how to ask.

Movement 1: The man nobody asked

Let us begin with the question, because the question tells us something about the people asking it.

"Who sinned, this man or his parents?"

In the world of the Bible, that was not an unreasonable question. There were texts that seemed to connect suffering and sin. The book of Deuteronomy promised blessings for obedience and curses for disobedience. The wisdom literature warned that the wicked would not prosper. Job's friends built an entire theology on the equation: if you are suffering, you must have done something.

But the Bible is not a flat book. It is a library of voices in conversation. And one of the loudest voices in that library is the book of Job, which spends forty-two chapters refusing the simple equation. Job is righteous. Job suffers. His friends explain. God finally speaks, and the explanation is not an explanation at all. It is a whirlwind, a world larger than Job's accounting, and a rebuke for the friends who thought they had God figured out (Job 42:7).

Jesus stands in that tradition here. He does not say, "All suffering is a display of God's glory." He says that in this particular case, the works of God would be displayed in this particular man. That is a claim about this story, not a formula for every diagnosis. If you take this verse and use it to tell a grieving mother that her child's death is "for God's glory," you have turned a door into a club. That is not what Jesus is doing.

What Jesus is doing is refusing the premise. The disciples want to know who is guilty. Jesus wants to show them who is at work.

There is a difference between those two questions, and the difference is a person.

The disciples see a problem. Jesus sees a man. The disciples want a verdict. Jesus wants a display of the works of God. The disciples are looking for a defendant. Jesus is looking at a son.

We have better tools than the disciples did, and we still do it. We have diagnoses and frameworks and support groups and theological systems, and all of them can become ways of keeping a person at arm's length. We label the suffering and think we have loved the sufferer. We explain the wound and think we have bound it. But a label is not a relationship. A diagnosis is not a name. The man in John 9 did not need another theory about why he was blind. He needed someone to see him. That is what Jesus does first. Before the mud, before the pool, before the miracle, Jesus sees him. The text says, "As he passed by, he saw a man blind from birth" (John 9:1). The disciples saw a theological problem. Jesus saw a man. The difference is the whole story.

Notice, too, what Jesus says about the timing. "We must work the works of him who sent me while it is day; night is coming, when no one can work." There is a clock running in this story. Jesus is on his way to the cross. The light will not be in the world forever in the same way. The night is coming. The window is open now.

That is true for us as well. We do not have unlimited time to do the works of God. We do not have unlimited Sundays. We do not have unlimited opportunities to sit with the person nobody asked, to speak the truth to the room that does not want to hear it, to go looking for the one who has been cast out. The night is coming. Do the work while it is day.

But the deepest thing in this first movement is not the timetable. It is the initiative. The man does not ask. Jesus comes.

That is the shape of grace in this story. It is not a reward for a good question. It is not a response to a desperate prayer. It is not the result of a program or a technique. It is the light walking toward a man who has no idea he is about to be found.

Some of you have been in church long enough to believe that God shows up when you get your act together. You think the order is: clean up, then come. Understand, then believe. Ask correctly, then receive. This story reverses the order. The man is still blind when the mud touches his eyes. He is still blind when he walks to the pool. He is still blind when he hears the water. He does not know who Jesus is until after he can see.

Grace arrives before the ask. That is what makes it grace.

Movement 2: Mud and the Sent Pool

"Having said these things, he spit on the ground and made mud with the saliva. Then he anointed the man's eyes with the mud" (John 9:6).

I want you to picture this. It is not a clean miracle. It is not a beam of light. It is spit and dust. It is a finger pressing wet clay onto a pair of eyes that have never worked. It is intimate, and it is a little bit undignified. If you were writing a gospel and you wanted to make Jesus look impressive, you would not start with spit.

But John is not writing to impress you. He is writing to show you who Jesus is.

Go back to the first pages of the Bible. "Then the LORD God formed the man of dust from the ground and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life, and the man became a living creature" (Genesis 2:7). The first human being was made from dust. Here, in the middle of a street, the Word who made everything from dust takes dust again — mixed now with his own saliva — and touches a face the world had written off.

This is not a random detail. It is a creation echo. The one who made the eye is remaking an eye. The one who formed the first man from the ground is forming sight in a man the religious experts had already filed under "born in sin." The Creator is not embarrassed by dust. He uses it.

There is a hard beauty in that. The thing you think disqualifies you — the body that does not work, the story that does not make sense, the diagnosis you did not choose, the family you did not pick, the life that has not gone according to plan — is not outside God's capacity to work. It is the material he uses. He is not limited to clean surfaces. He makes things out of dirt.

Then the instruction: "Go, wash in the pool of Siloam" (John 9:7).

John stops the scene to translate the name: Siloam means "Sent." The man is sent by the Sent One, to the Sent pool. The sending is the point. The one who is called "the light of the world" sends a blind man to a pool whose name means "sent," and the man goes.

But hear what the instruction costs. The man is still blind. He cannot see the street. He cannot see the direction. He cannot see the pool when he arrives. He has mud drying on his eyes and a voice he can no longer hear ringing in his ears. How does he get there?

The way anyone moves through the dark: step by step, by trust.

Think about what that walk cost him. He had to trust a voice he had just met. He had to trust a direction he could not verify. He had to trust that the pool was where the voice said it was, that the water was real, that the mud would not make things worse. Every step was a small act of faith. There were no signs along the road. There was no crowd cheering him on. There was no evidence that any of this would work. There was just the word. And the word was enough.

That is not blind faith. It is faith in a voice. The man had heard something in that voice that made him go. He did not know the doctrine. He did not know the destination. He knew the one who spoke. And that knowledge was enough to move his feet.

This is one of the most underrated pictures of faith in the New Testament. We talk a lot about seeing and believing. Here is a man who believes without seeing. He cannot verify the route. He cannot check the map. He cannot see whether the water is clean. He has nothing to go on but the word of a stranger and the mud on his face. And he goes.

He finds the pool. He washes. And for the first time in his life — light.

We are not told what he saw first. John, who gives us every other detail, writes it in six words: "So he went and washed and came back seeing" (John 9:7). That is it. No description of color. No account of the sky. No first words. Just the fact. He went. He washed. He came back seeing.

Maybe you have wondered what it would be like to see for the first time. The first face. The first tree. The first shaft of sunlight on a stone floor. John does not tell us. Perhaps because the point is not the visual. The point is the obedience. The point is that the man trusted the word of the one he could not see, and the word led him to sight.

The pool is real. This is not a fable set in a made-up city. The Pool of Siloam is one of the most striking archaeological discoveries in modern Jerusalem. For nearly two thousand years, it was a name in a book with nowhere on earth to stand. Rome destroyed Jerusalem in AD 70. The pool fell out of use, silted over, and the city grew on top of it. Then, in 2004, a crew repairing a sewage pipe in the oldest part of the city hit cut stone. Archaeologists moved in. They uncovered a massive stepped pool of the kind pilgrims descended into before climbing up to the temple. Coins found in the excavation dated it to the Second Temple period. In 2023, after two decades of digging, the full extent of the pool was finally brought to light.

The water that filled it came through Hezekiah's tunnel, a channel cut through roughly half a kilometer of solid rock in the eighth century BC. The Bible mentions the project in a single line: "Hezekiah made the pool and the conduit and brought water into the city" (2 Kings 20:20). In 1880, explorers found an inscription inside the tunnel, carved by the original diggers, describing

the moment two crews met underground and the water flowed from the spring to the pool. The pool was a place of purification, a place of pilgrimage, a place where the city came to wash.

And Jesus sends a blind man there.

There is an echo here that would have been loud to John's first readers. The prophet Isaiah had spoken of "the waters of Shiloah that flow gently" (Isaiah 8:6). The same pool. The same gentle water. The prophet accused the people of refusing those waters, of trusting in bigger powers and louder alliances. And now the Sent One sends a man nobody asked to the waters of Shiloah, and the man comes back seeing.

The room had a file. The pool had water. The light had a plan.

Movement 3: The neighbors and the first testimony

The man comes back to his neighborhood, and the neighborhood does not know what to do with him.

"The neighbors and those who had seen him before as a beggar were saying, 'Is not this the man who used to sit and beg?' Some said, 'It is he.' Others said, 'No, but he is like him.' He said, 'I am the man'" (John 9:8–9).

There is something heartbreaking and wonderful in that sentence. For his whole life, this man had been known by what he lacked. He was the blind beggar. He was the one at the gate. He was the condition on the corner. And now the condition is gone, and the neighbors cannot recognize him. They argue about his identity with him standing right there.

The first time in his life he can look back at the people looking at him, and they are not sure he is himself.

So he says it. "I am the man." Not "I was the man." Not "I used to be the man." I am. The light has given him a self that is not the same as his suffering.

Then they ask how. And he tells them the story.

"The man called Jesus made mud and anointed my eyes and said to me, 'Go to Siloam and wash.' So I went and washed and received my sight" (John 9:11).

That is the first testimony in the chapter. Notice how simple it is. He does not give them a systematic theology. He does not explain the hypostatic union. He does not answer the question of why he was born blind. He says what happened. He names the one who did it as

best he can: "the man called Jesus." He does not even know where Jesus is. When they ask, "Where is he?" he says, "I do not know" (John 9:12).

And that is enough. That is enough to start. That is enough to be a witness.

We have a habit in the church of thinking that testimony has to be polished. We want the before-and-after photo, the tidy narrative, the three-point conversion story, the answer to every objection. We want to be able to say, "Here is what I believe about the atonement, the Trinity, the doctrine of Scripture, and the problem of evil" before we are allowed to say, "I was blind, and now I see."

The man in John 9 did not have any of that. He had a name, a pool, and a pair of eyes that worked. And he told the truth.

His understanding grows through the chapter. Watch it. In verse 11, Jesus is "the man called Jesus." In verse 17, when the Pharisees ask him, he says, "He is a prophet." In verse 33, he says, "If this man were not from God, he could do nothing." In verse 38, he says, "Lord, I believe," and he worships him.

The man's Christology is a sunrise. It comes in stages. First a name, then a prophet, then a man from God, then Lord. That is how faith usually works. It is not a single flash. It is a dawn.

If you are a new believer, do not be ashamed that you do not know everything yet. The man did not know everything when he was healed. He did not know everything when he testified. He did not know everything when they threw him out. He knew one thing, and he held on to it, and the light kept growing.

If you have been a believer for forty years, do not despise the dawn. The man's simple testimony was the beginning of a worship that would outlast the room that rejected him.

Movement 4: The interrogations

The neighbors bring him to the Pharisees. And the story turns into a courtroom.

The healing happened on the Sabbath. That is the charge. Jesus had made clay — kneading, which their tradition counted as work. He had healed a man on the day of rest. And so the miracle goes on trial, and the healer is not in the room.

The Pharisees ask the man how he received his sight. He tells them. And they divide.

"Some of the Pharisees said, 'This man is not from God, for he does not keep the Sabbath.' But others said, 'How can a man who is a sinner do such signs?' And there was a division among them" (John 9:16).

That is an important detail. Not every Pharisee is a villain in this story. There is a split. Some are certain. Some are unsettled. The room is not a monolith. It is a group of people trying to fit a miracle into a framework that cannot hold it.

They ask the man what he thinks. "What do you say about him, since he has opened your eyes?" He says, "He is a prophet" (John 9:17).

That answer makes them nervous. A prophet is a dangerous category. A prophet speaks for God. A prophet can challenge the experts. So they bring in his parents.

The parents are afraid. John tells us why: "The Jews had already agreed that if anyone should confess Jesus to be Christ, he was to be put out of the synagogue" (John 9:22). That is the threat. Not a fine. Not a warning. Expulsion. The community that had known their son since he was born would close its doors to him if they said the wrong thing.

So they say the safe thing. "We know that this is our son and that he was born blind. But how he now sees we do not know, nor do we know who opened his eyes. Ask him; he is of age; he will speak for himself" (John 9:20–21).

Their son is standing right there. And the family goes quiet to stay safe.

I do not want to be too hard on them. Fear is a real power. The cost of confession is real. If you have ever stayed silent in a room because speaking would cost you your job, your family, your place in the community, you know something of what is happening here. The parents are not cartoon cowards. They are frightened people in a frightened system.

But their silence is still a choice. And the son they protected by their silence is about to be thrown out anyway. Fear often buys a safety it cannot keep.

We do the same thing. We calculate the cost of telling the truth and decide that silence is prudence. We call it wisdom. We call it timing. We call it being careful with our witness. Sometimes it is. But sometimes it is just fear wearing a respectable coat. The parents chose the room over their son, and the room threw him out anyway. That is what fear does. It promises to protect you and then leaves you with nothing to protect. The only safe place in this story is in the hands of the one who was willing to be thrown out. The man lost the room and found the Lord. His parents kept the room and lost the moment. I am not saying that every act of courage

will cost you everything. I am saying that fear is a bad master. It takes the thing you are most afraid to lose and makes it the thing that rules you.

They call him back a second time. This is no longer a hearing. It is a squeeze.

"Give glory to God. We know that this man is a sinner" (John 9:24).

"Give glory to God" is a formula. It means, "Tell the truth in the presence of God." But they have already told him what the truth is supposed to be. They are not asking him to say what he saw. They are asking him to say what they have decided. They want him to agree that the one who gave him sight is a sinner.

And here is where the man with no schooling, no title, no standing, and nothing to lose says one of the boldest sentences in the Gospels.

"Whether he is a sinner I do not know. One thing I know, that though I was blind, now I see" (John 9:25).

One thing I know.

That is not a complete answer. It is not a theology. It is not a defense. It is a fact. And facts are stubborn things. You can argue with a person's interpretation. You cannot easily argue with a person's experience. They can call Jesus a sinner. They cannot call the man's eyes a lie.

They push again. "What did he do to you? How did he open your eyes?" He answers, "I have told you already, and you would not listen. Why do you want to hear it again? Do you also want to become his disciples?" (John 9:26).

You have to love the courage in that. The man is alone in a room full of powerful men, and he is teasing them. He knows what they are doing. He knows they are not looking for the truth. He has stopped pretending that this is a fair hearing.

They revile him. "You are his disciple, but we are disciples of Moses. We know that God has spoken to Moses, but as for this man, we do not know where he comes from" (John 9:28).

And the man answers with the simplest logic in the world. "Why, this is an amazing thing! You do not know where he comes from, and yet he opened my eyes. We know that God does not listen to sinners, but if anyone is a worshiper of God and does his will, God listens to him. Never since the world began has it been heard that anyone opened the eyes of a man born blind. If this man were not from God, he could do nothing" (John 9:30–33).

It is not sophisticated. It is not the kind of argument you would make at a seminary. It is the argument of a man who can see. A good tree produces good fruit. A man sent from God opens blind eyes. I did not have eyes this morning. I have them now. Work it out.

They cannot work it out. So they swing.

"You were born in utter sin, and would you teach us?" And they cast him out (John 9:34).

There it is. The room that should have protected him expels him. The people who had a category for him — "the blind beggar" — cannot handle him as a seeing man. The verdict they brought into the room at the beginning comes back in the end: born in sin. The very thing Jesus said was not the man's fault becomes the weapon used to throw him out.

He loses his community for telling the truth about his own eyes.

That is the cost of testimony. Not always. Not everywhere. But sometimes. A family that will not talk about what happened. A friend group that goes silent. A church that would rather keep its categories than receive the one Christ has found. The man was not thrown out because he was wrong. He was thrown out because he was right.

And he was alone in the street.

Movement 5: Cast out and found

"Jesus heard that they had cast him out, and having found him he said, 'Do you believe in the Son of Man?'" (John 9:35).

That sentence is the whole gospel in a hallway.

They threw him out. Jesus went looking.

The chapter does not say the man went looking for Jesus. It says Jesus found him. The man did not know where Jesus was. He had never seen his face. He had heard his voice in the street, felt his fingers on his eyes, and then lost him in the crowd. Now he is alone, and the one who healed him comes looking.

This is the first time in the story that Jesus and the man speak face to face. The man has been talking about Jesus all day. He has been interrogated about Jesus. He has been thrown out for Jesus. But he has never seen him.

And now he can.

"Do you believe in the Son of Man?"

"Who is he, sir, that I may believe in him?"

"You have seen him, and it is he who is speaking with you."

"Lord, I believe." And he worshiped him (John 9:35–38).

The first face he sees is the face of the one who made him see. The first voice he recognizes is the voice that sent him to the pool. The man who was thrown out of the house of God worships the Son of God in the street.

There is no building in that scene. There is no liturgy. There is no altar. There is a man on a dusty road, with mud still drying in his imagination, bowing before the light of the world. And that is enough. That is more than enough.

The chapter does not end there. It ends with a warning.

Jesus says, "For judgment I came into this world, that those who do not see may see, and those who see may become blind" (John 9:39).

Some of the Pharisees hear him and ask, "Are we also blind?"

And Jesus answers, "If you were blind, you would have no guilt; but now that you say, 'We see,' your guilt remains" (John 9:40–41).

That is the great reversal of John 9. The man who was born blind sees. The men who were sure they could see are blind. The man who was cast out is found. The men who stayed inside are lost. The one who had no name in the question is given a name by the Son of Man. The ones who had all the answers do not have the one answer that matters.

The chapter is not a celebration of the outsider and a condemnation of the insider. It is a warning to anyone who thinks their sight is a possession instead of a gift. The Pharisees were not blind because they lacked information. They were blind because they had decided they already saw. The man was not seeing because he was smart. He was seeing because the light came to him.

That is the difference between religion and revelation. Religion can give you a file. Revelation gives you a face.

And a face changes everything. You cannot worship a file. You cannot love a category. You cannot be found by a verdict. The man in John 9 was not converted by an argument. He was converted by a person. He had heard the voice in the street, felt the fingers on his eyes, walked

to the pool on the strength of a word, and then stood in front of the one who had done it all. The light was not an idea. The light was a man. That is why the chapter ends with worship, not with a doctrine exam. The man does not say, "Now I understand everything." He says, "Lord, I believe." And he bows.

That is still the invitation. Not to understand everything. Not to have every answer. Not to be able to explain the suffering or the silence or the waiting. To see him. To hear him. To bow.

Application: What do you do with the light?

So what do you do now?

You have heard the question in the street. You have seen the mud. You have walked to the pool. You have stood in the interrogation. You have watched the man get thrown out and then found. You have heard the warning at the end.

What do you do with the light?

Let me give you four responses. Not four steps to earn anything. Four ways to live in front of what you have seen.

1. Stop writing the case file

The disciples wanted to know who sinned. Jesus wanted to show them what God was doing. That is the difference between a file and a person.

Before you offer an explanation for someone's suffering, sit with them long enough to learn their name. Before you tell them why it happened, ask them how they are. Before you turn their life into a theology lecture, let them be a human being.

That does not mean you never speak truth. It means you earn the right to speak it. It means you do not use doctrine as a shield against compassion. It means you do not reduce a person to the worst thing that has happened to them or the most visible thing about them.

The man in John 9 was a case study to the disciples and a son to Jesus. Which room are you in?

Ask yourself a concrete question this week: whose suffering have I explained without ever asking their name? Whose pain have I turned into a lesson? Whose life have I reduced to a cautionary tale? Go to that person. Not with a lecture. With a chair. Sit down. Listen. Let them be more than their wound. That is not a small thing. It is the beginning of sight.

2. Say what you know

You do not need a complete theology to testify. You need one thing.

"One thing I know: I was blind, and now I see."

What is your one thing? Maybe it is a moment when the light broke through. Maybe it is a slow dawn. Maybe it is a prayer that was answered, or a prayer that was not answered and a grace that held you anyway. Maybe it is the day you stopped running. Maybe it is the day you stopped pretending.

You do not have to understand everything. You do not have to be able to answer every objection. You do not have to have the whole Bible memorized. You have to tell the truth about what Jesus has done in your life.

Your testimony is not the whole story. It is your story. And your story is enough to start.

3. Go looking for the cast-out

Jesus heard that they had cast him out, and he went looking.

Who has been cast out of your church, your family, your friendship, your workplace? Who is sitting in the street right now because they told the truth and the room could not handle it? Who is the person you explained instead of loved?

Go find them.

The church should be the first place the cast-out are found, not the last. We should be the people who leave the room to look for the one the room threw out. We should be the ones who do not wait for the outsider to clean up, understand, or find their way back. We should go.

That is what Jesus did. He heard. He found. He spoke.

4. Worship before you see the whole picture

The man worshiped in the street. He did not have a full Christology. He did not know the doctrine of the incarnation. He did not know about the cross and the resurrection. He knew that the one who had given him sight was standing in front of him, and he bowed.

You may not have all the answers. You may not understand why you were born the way you were born, or why the thing happened the way it happened, or why the prayer was not answered the way you wanted. You can still bow.

The light is not a theory. It is a person. And a person can be worshiped before they are fully understood.

That is not anti-intellectual. It is the order of the gospel. The man saw, and then he worshiped, and then he grew. The Pharisees had the file, and they stayed in the dark.

The invitation

This invitation is for two people.

The first is the man outside. If you have been cast out — by a church, by a family, by a room that decided your suffering was your fault or your testimony was too much — hear this: Jesus has heard. He is looking for you. He does not wait for you to clean up, understand, or find your way back. He comes to the street. He comes to the place where the room left you. He comes with a question, not a verdict: "Do you believe in the Son of Man?"

The second is the person inside. If you have been the one with the file, the verdict, the room, the right answer — hear this too: Jesus is looking for you. The chapter ends with a warning, not a celebration. The man who saw was thrown out; the men who thought they saw were left in the dark. You can come out of the room. You can admit that you are blind. You can let the light give you sight.

The night is coming. The window is open now. The light is still walking.

Come while it is day.

Response

In a moment, I am going to ask you to do something simple. Not to come forward. Not to stand. Not to sing. Just to be quiet.

In the quiet, name the label you have been carrying. Maybe it is a label someone gave you: "the one who sinned," "the one who was born wrong," "the outsider," "the project," "the failure," "the one who asks too much." Say it to God. Do not defend yourself. Do not explain it. Just name it.

Then say the man's sentence: "One thing I know."

One thing. Not ten. Not a complete theology. One thing Jesus has done, or one thing you have seen, or one thing you are still hoping for. Say it in your own words. Let it be small and true.

Then ask him one question: "Jesus, let me see you."

Do not answer too quickly. Let the mud dry. Let the pool be a place you have to walk to in the dark. Let the room be a room you have to leave. And then, if you can, tell him one thing you will do this week. One person you will go looking for. One file you will close. One sentence of testimony you will speak.

Let us pray.

Lord Jesus, you are the light of the world, and you walked toward a man who had no way to ask for help. Forgive us for the questions that turn suffering into a case file. Forgive us for the rooms that throw people out. Give us the humility to say what we know and the courage to say it when it costs us. Thank you that when the world casts us out, you come looking. Thank you that you do not wait for us to see before you come.

Open our eyes. And then open our hands. Make us a church where the cast-out are found, where the blind can say "One thing I know," and where the ones who think they see can admit they need the light.

We ask this in your name. Amen.

Closing

They threw him out.

Jesus went looking.

The light of the world walked toward a man who never asked. He put mud on his eyes. He sent him to the pool. He found him in the street. And the man who had never seen his own face saw the face of God.

He is still walking. He is still finding. He is still giving sight.

May we be the people who say, "One thing I know."

And may we be the people who go looking for the ones the room threw out.

Evidence note for the preacher

- John 9 is the longest sustained account of a single healing in the four Gospels: one chapter, forty-one verses. The man is never named. The narrative is built like a courtroom drama, with witnesses, interrogations, a family under pressure, and a verdict.

- The Pool of Siloam is real. It was discovered in 2004 during a sewage repair in the City of David and excavated over the following years; in 2023 its full extent was brought to light. It was a monumental stepped pool from the Second Temple period, likely used for ritual purification by pilgrims. The water came through Hezekiah's tunnel, roughly 533 meters of rock-cut channel from the Gihon Spring. The Siloam inscription, found in 1880, records the meeting of the two digging crews. See 2 Kings 20:20; 2 Chronicles 32:30; Nehemiah 3:15.
- The archaeology confirms the pool's existence, location, and date, and the Gospel's knowledge of first-century Jerusalem. It does not by itself prove that a particular blind man was healed there. The setting is credible; the miracle remains a claim the text asks you to trust.
- "Siloam" means "Sent" (John 9:7). John translates the name for his readers. Isaiah 8:6 speaks of "the waters of Shiloah that flow gently"; the pool was a known landmark and a place of water and worship.
- The disciples' question reflects a theology of retribution that the Bible itself complicates. Compare Job 42:7; Psalm 73; Ezekiel 18:1–32; Luke 13:1–5. Jesus' answer is specific to this man ("that the works of God might be displayed in him"), not a universal formula for all suffering.
- The man never asks to be healed in John 9. Jesus takes the initiative. This is a key point of the sermon and should not be softened into "the man's faith healed him."
- The Sabbath controversy concerned the making of clay, which some traditions counted as kneading, and therefore work. John 9:16 records a division among the Pharisees; not all of them are uniformly hostile.
- The parents' fear is explained in John 9:22: the leadership had agreed that anyone who confessed Jesus as the Christ would be put out of the synagogue. Their silence is a pastoral and theological point, not a cartoon.
- The man's Christology develops: "the man called Jesus" (9:11), "a prophet" (9:17), "from God" (9:33), "Lord" (9:38). The sermon uses this progression deliberately.
- "Give glory to God" (9:24) is a formula calling for truthful testimony before God (compare Joshua 7:19). The leaders have already predetermined the answer.
- The man's argument in 9:30–33 is a simple inference from the miracle, not a full theology of revelation. It is enough to get him thrown out and enough to get him found.
- John 9:38 ("Lord, I believe," and he worshiped him) is retained in the ESV and is the climax of the chapter. Some textual witnesses have a shorter reading; the sermon follows the ESV.
- John 9:39–41 is the warning that keeps the chapter from becoming a simple story of an outsider hero. The Pharisees who say "We see" are the ones left in blindness. This is a word to the church, not only to the first-century synagogue.
- The "tower of Siloam" in Luke 13:4 may have stood near the pool; the sermon does not use it as a specific archaeological identification, only as a reminder that Jesus rejected the simple equation between disaster and sin.
- The healed man's worship in the street is a picture of the church's calling: the ones who have been found go looking for the ones still outside. The application is intentionally concrete.